

STORY BIBLE · CANON REFERENCE

THE BINDING

Every connection has a consequence.

The story, the rules and the Thing in the water

The single source of truth for the story of the game, for the creator, for Codex and for future Claude sessions. It covers Saskia and Tess, the linking game, Mum's four rules, the secret **SASKIA = TESS**, the four ways the Thing hunts for their breath, the endings, and how each story rule becomes a game system.

CANON PROPOSED RETIRED

VERSION 2.1 · 4 NOVEMBER 2026

SUPERSEDES THE v1.1 NARRATIVE FOUNDATION AS STORY CANON

THE BINDING: Story Bible v2.1

Contents

1 The game at a glance

2 World and setting

3 Characters

4 The Binding: the rules of linking

5 Mum's four rules

6 The secret: SASKIA = TESS

7 The Thing in the water

8 The story of the night

9 The endings

10 From story to game systems

11 Tone, look and sound

12 Voice and dialogue reference

13 Timeline and fact sheet

14 Retired ideas: do not use

15 Open questions for the creator

16 The v4 trailer, shot by shot

17 Change log

0 How to use this document

This is the **single source of truth** for the story of *THE BINDING*. It is written for three readers: you (the creator), coding assistants such as Codex, and future Claude sessions. Anyone building, writing or designing for the game should read sections 1 to 9 before starting.

The three labels

Label	Meaning	What an assistant may do with it
CANON	Approved by the creator in conversation. This is the story.	Build on it. Never change it without the creator's explicit OK.
PROPOSED	A suggestion that fills a gap or resolves a contradiction. It has *not* been approved yet.	Use it as a working default so work isn't blocked, but flag it in your notes. Replace it the moment the creator decides otherwise.
RETIRED	From an earlier draft. Replaced or rejected.	Never use it, even if an older file (such as the v1.1 PDF) says otherwise.

Order of authority

1. The creator's latest instruction.
2. This document (Story Bible v2.1, 4 November 2026).
3. The v4 trailer and its cue sheet (it shows the canon story; its exact on-screen wording is listed in section 12).
4. The older *Definitive Narrative Foundation* PDF (v1.1, 18 October 2026). That document describes an **earlier story** (the "Held Breath" version). Use it only for craft ideas, research and place detail. Where it disagrees with this document, this document wins.

> **RULES FOR AI COLLABORATORS (CODEX, CLAUDE AND OTHERS)**
>
> - Do not invent new lore and present it as fact. If something is missing, write it as a clearly marked proposal and ask.
> - The Thing has a design now: **the Bound One** (section 7.8). Show it the way 7.6 says: rarely, in the dark, by the light the player carries.
> - Tags are always written in capitals, in the form **THING = THING**. Names on tags are written in full: **SASKIA = TESS**, never "SAS = TESS".
> - Breaking a link (tearing or burning its tag) is always safe and always good. Never design a punishment for breaking a link (its only cost is losing the help that link gave).
> - Keep it realistic: no gore beyond what the creature design itself carries (7.8), no logos, no 2D "painted" effects pretending to be physical water or rain.
> - Check section 15 (open questions) before building anything that depends on an unresolved point.

1 The game at a glance

Item	Value	Status
Title	**THE BINDING**	CANON
Tagline	*Every connection has a consequence.*	CANON
Genre	First-person psychological horror, single player. Slow dread, grounded realism, no gore, no visible monster.	CANON
Engine and platform	Unreal Engine 5, PC (Windows) first.	CANON
Scope	One night. Two buildings across a flood: the family cottage and the old pumping station.	CANON
Player character	Saskia, 38, a former freediver who can hold her breath for a very long time.	CANON

Logline PROPOSED wording

On the night of a great flood, a former freediver tries to guide her trapped sister to safety using a childhood game that joins any two things together, and learns that something drowned in the fen has found both their names, and wants their breath.

The horror in one line CANON

It hears you breathe, it counts to join you, it breathes with you, and it walks you into the water.

Design pillars CANON

1. **Linking is the tool; breaking a link is the good act.** Every link you make helps Tess and is also a path for the Thing. Tearing or burning a tag is always safe.
2. **Breath is the game.** The Thing hunts by the sound of breathing. Saskia's freediver skill, holding her breath, is how she hides, how she survives and how the game ends (one held breath in the flooded engine pit).
3. **The Thing is never shown.** The player sees only what it touches: dimming lamps, knocking pipes, a counting voice, a third breath, a pale wet hand on glass.
4. **Realism above everything.** Real places, real water, real sound. The horror comes from rules the player understands, not from gore or jump-scare spam.
5. **One night, two sisters, one telephone.** Their relationship is the heart of the game.

The core loop in three verbs CANON

Verb	What the player does	Why it matters
Link	Tess tells you on the phone what is blocking her. You link and use things in your house to open her path, room by room.	Helping Tess is the goal, but each link is also a road the Thing can travel.
Break	When the Thing comes too close, you tear or burn a tag. The path closes.	It is the safe, good act, but Tess loses that help too.
Keep her awake	Keep talking to Tess on the phone. If she falls asleep she breathes through you, and the Thing can reach that breath.	A constant pressure running under everything else.

2 World and setting

2.1 The place CANON

The English Fens: flat, drained marshland, much of it below sea level, held dry by pumps, drains and sluices. One stormy night the fen floods. The flat black water stretches to the horizon, broken by reed tops, fence posts and drowned willows. Rain, wind and mist all night.

2.2 Key locations

Location	Description	Status
The family cottage	Where Saskia is. Small, old, cold. The kitchen has Mum's four rules painted on the wall and the old crank wall telephone. The kitchen lamp is linked to the engine-house lamp. A hall runs to the front door, which faces the flood.	CANON
The engine house (the old pumping station)	Across the floodwater. A Victorian brick engine house with tall arched windows and a chimney. Tess is trapped inside as the water rises. Under it is the **engine pit**, now flooded, where the original **SASKIA = TESS** tag lies and where the Thing lives.	CANON (look from the trailer)
The floodwater between them	Black, cold, deep. Saskia cannot simply cross it during most of the game. In the finale she goes into it.	CANON
The sluice	The old iron sluice gate in the brick channel between the buildings. In the storm the high drain pours over it.	PROPOSED (shown in trailer)
The navigation beacon	An old lantern on a timber post out on the flood, flashing once every five seconds. A landmark the player can see from the cottage.	PROPOSED (shown in trailer)

2.3 Names and dates carried over from the earlier bible PROPOSED

The v1.1 PDF used these names. They fit the new story and can be kept unless you change them:

- Family surname: **Moerland** (Saskia Moerland, Tess Moerland).
- Mum's name: **Ruth** Moerland.
- The pumping station: **Coldmere Engine**, in the Cambridgeshire Fens.
- The night of the game: **24 October 2026**.

Note: the v1.1 PDF described Coldmere as a 1928 diesel station. The trailer shows an older Victorian brick engine house with a chimney. Pick one look before building the level (open question Q8).

2.4 Time of the game

CANON One night, the night of the flood. The present day: Saskia is 38 and was six in 1994, so the game is set in 2026.

3 Characters

3.1 Saskia (the player) CANON

- Age 38. Tess's older sister.
- A former freediver: she can hold her breath for a very long time. This is her gameplay skill (hiding from the Thing, the final dive).
- At six she wrote the tag **SASKIA = TESS** and joined her breath to her baby sister's, thinking it was a game. She has breathed for Tess every time Tess sleeps, ever since, without knowing it.

PROPOSED CHARACTER DETAIL PROPOSED

- She left home years ago and has not been back much (from an earlier draft of the new story). Coming home on the flood night carries guilt and distance between the sisters.
- Her freediving career is over. The reason is not decided (open question Q11). A hint that her body has always been working for two would be a strong, quiet clue.

3.2 Tess CANON

- Age 32. Saskia's younger sister.
- Born with a rare condition: **when she falls asleep, she stops breathing.**
- Tonight she is trapped by the flood inside the engine house. The sisters can only talk on the old crank telephone.
- She remembers their childhood game. She is the one who tied the lamp tag, in her handwriting: *"So I know you're in."*
- If she falls asleep tonight, she breathes through Saskia, and the Thing can slip into that breath. Keeping her awake matters.

PROPOSED CHARACTER DETAIL PROPOSED

- She stayed home and looks after the old pumping station, which is why she is there tonight (from an earlier draft of the new story).
- Voice: warm, practical, teasing, exhausted. She uses humour to stay calm and to keep her sister calm. As the night goes on she struggles to stay awake.
- Everyone, Tess included, believes she "grew out of" her condition as a small child. Only Mum knew the real reason she breathes at night.

3.3 Mum CANON

- Dead before the game begins.
- She knew the family secret. She painted the four rules on the kitchen wall (section 5).
- She hated the game ("Mum hated that game", trailer).
- Her notes, found during the night, are how Saskia learns the truth about **SASKIA = TESS**.
- She kept a tin. In it is an old crayon tag reading **SASKIA = TESS** (trailer). What exactly that tag is: see open question Q2.

PROPOSED Name: Ruth Moerland. How and when she died is not decided (Q9).

3.4 The Thing CANON

- Something drowned, down in the fen water. It has been under the floodwater since 1994.
- It has no breath of its own. **It wants the two sisters' breath.**
- In the 1994 flood the **SASKIA = TESS** tag fell into the water. The Thing found it, and found their names. It learned the game from the tag.
- It is never shown. Full rules in section 7.

PROPOSED Never explain what it was. No backstory reveal, no face, no name. The less the player knows, the worse it is.

3.5 Who is not in the story RETIRED

Dad drowning in 1994 and coming "home" through the links was an earlier version of the twist. It is retired (section 14). Dad may exist as a background fact, but he is not the Thing and not a twist.

4 The Binding: the rules of linking

The sisters' childhood game is real. Mum called it a danger. The player uses it all night.

4.1 The canon rules CANON

#	Rule	Detail
1	Write a tag	Write on a paper tag what you are joining, in the form **THING = THING**. For example **KITCHEN LAMP = ENGINE HOUSE LAMP**.
2	Tie it on, touch both, count to three	Tie the tag on, touch both things, and count to three. On "three" they are **joined**. (The Thing learned this rule from the old tag: "touch, count to three, and it's joined".)
3	Joined things share everything	Whatever happens to one happens to the other. Turn off your lamp and her lamp goes off. Open your door and her door opens.
4	Breaking is always safe	Tear or burn the tag and the link is broken. Breaking is the safe, good act. Its only cost is losing whatever help that link gave.
5	Every link is a path	The Thing moves through linked things. Every link you make to help Tess is also a road for it, towards you.

4.2 What "share everything" means in play PROPOSED

To make the rule easy to build and easy to read, each linkable object has a few simple **states**, and a link copies state changes in both directions:

State	Examples	Story use
On / off	Lamps, the hall light, a radio, a pump switch	The first lesson: your lamp off, her lamp off.
Open / closed	Doors, hatches, windows, valves, the sluice	Opening Tess's path room by room.
Wet / dry, filling / draining	Sinks, tanks, buckets, a flooded room	Draining her room can flood yours.
Sound	Bells, the phone, pipes, a ticking clock	The Thing listens through linked things.
Touch	Anything joined	If the Thing touches one end while you hold the other, it starts counting (section 7.3).

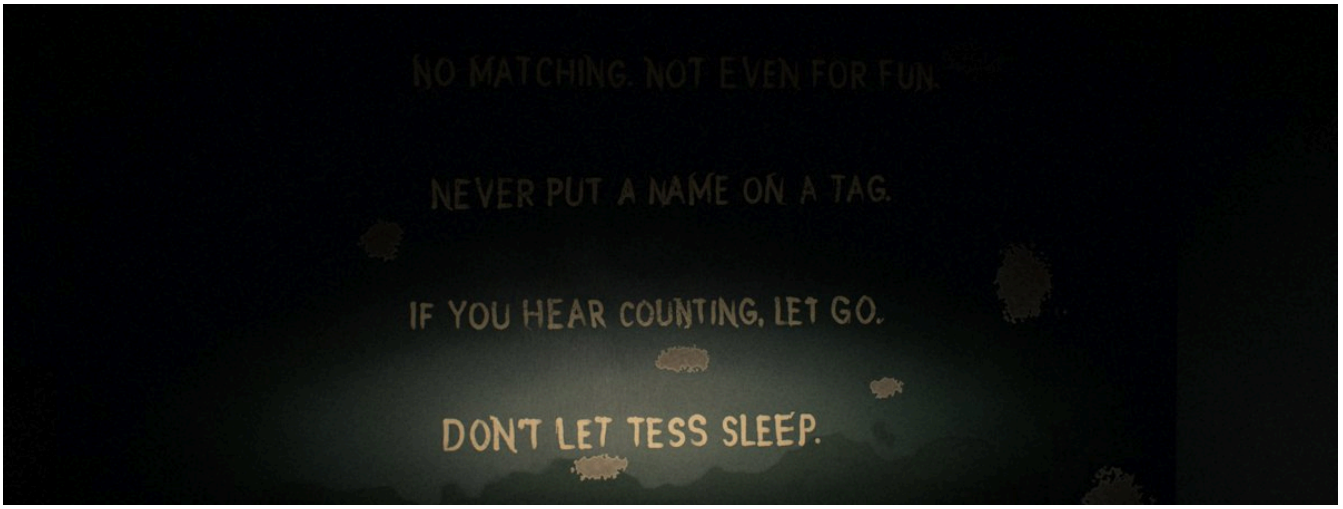
4.3 Linking things that are far apart PROPOSED

A lamp in the cottage and a lamp in the engine house cannot share one tag. Proposed rule: **tags come in matching pairs.** The same words are written on two tags, one tied to each thing. The link forms when both things are touched at once while the count reaches three. That is why it was a game for two sisters: one in the cottage, one in the engine house, counting together on the phone. Destroying either tag of a pair breaks the link. (Open question Q1.)

4.4 How the game teaches it (first minutes) CANON from the trailer

1. The phone rings. Tess: *"Saskia? It's me. The water's in the engine house… I can't get out."*
2. The kitchen lamp has a tag on it in Tess's handwriting.
3. Tess: *"Remember our game? Turn your lamp off."* Saskia switches it off. Across the water, the engine-house window goes dark.

4. Tess: *"See? It still works."*
5. Tess: *"Mum hated that game."* The torch finds Mum's rules on the wall.



Trailer v4: Mum's fourth rule, painted on the kitchen wall. Mood reference, not final art.

5 Mum's four rules

Painted on the kitchen wall in Mum's hand. Each one is a warning the player understands fully only later. CANON (wording as shown in the trailer)

Rule on the wall	What it really means	How the game teaches or tests it
1. NO MATCHING. NOT EVEN FOR FUN.	Don't play the linking game at all. Every link is a path for the Thing.	The player has to break this rule to help Tess. The cost shows itself in the middle of the night.
2. NEVER PUT A NAME ON A TAG.	A name on a tag joins a *person*. That is how **SASKIA = TESS** was made, and how the Thing found them.	The reveal (section 6). PROPOSED The game never lets the player write a name on a tag.
3. IF YOU HEAR COUNTING, LET GO.	The Thing counts to three when it touches what you are touching. Letting go (or burning the tag) before "three" stops it joining you.	The counting event (section 7.3). The player learns to let go on "one... two...".
4. DON'T LET TESS SLEEP.	When Tess sleeps she breathes through Saskia, and the Thing can slip into that breath.	The third-breath event (section 7.4) and the phone calls that keep Tess awake.

PROPOSED: WHY MUM NEVER EXPLAINED

Mum could not undo the breath link without risking Tess's life, and she could not tell her daughters without them trying the game again. So she painted rules instead of reasons, and kept the truth in her tin and her notes. The player reads the rules as superstition at first, then as instructions.

6 The secret: SASKIA = TESS

6.1 What happened CANON

- When Tess was a baby, she kept stopping breathing in her sleep.
- Six-year-old Saskia, thinking it was a game, wrote a tag: **SASKIA = TESS**. That joined their breathing.
- Since that night, every time Tess sleeps, Saskia breathes for her. Neither of them has ever known.
- That same year, in the 1994 flood, the tag fell into the floodwater.
- **Something down in the water found it, and found their names.** It now knows the game and wants their breath.
- The original tag lies at the bottom of the flooded engine pit, where the Thing is.

6.2 How the player finds out CANON

In the middle of the night, Saskia finds Mum's notes and learns the truth about **SASKIA = TESS**. The trailer shows the torch finding an old crayon tag reading **SASKIA = TESS** in Mum's tin.



Trailer v4: the crayon tag in Mum's tin. Mood reference, not final art.

6.3 The tag in the tin versus the tag in the pit PROPOSED

The trailer shows a **SASKIA = TESS** tag in Mum's tin, but the canon ending needs the original tag at the bottom of the engine pit. Recommended answer: **the tin holds Saskia's first attempt**, a practice tag she wrote but never tied or touched. It has no power. Mum kept it as proof, with her notes. The real tag, the one that was tied and counted, went into the 1994 flood. (Open question Q2.)

6.4 Clues to plant before the reveal PROPOSED

- Saskia's breath meter drains slightly faster whenever Tess goes quiet on the phone.
- Saskia yawns or feels breathless at the exact moments Tess says she is "just resting her eyes".
- A childhood drawing of the game shows two stick girls joined by a string (the trailer shows a childhood drawing of the game).
- An old baby monitor or medical leaflet in a drawer, and a date in 1994 that matches the flood.
- Rule 2 on the wall has been painted over and repainted more than once.

7 The Thing in the water

It hears you breathe, it counts to join you, it breathes with you, and it walks you into the water. CANON

7.1 What it is and what it wants CANON

- Something drowned in the fen. It has no breath of its own. It wants the sisters' breath.
- It cannot see. It finds you by sound: **the sound of your breathing**.
- It moves through linked things, from the water towards you.
- It knows the game, including the count to three.

7.2 Behaviour 1: it hunts by listening for breath CANON

Part	Detail
Trigger	Run, panic or breathe hard near something linked, and it hears you and starts coming.
The tell	Water knocks through the pipes towards you, getting closer and louder. The nearest linked lamp slowly dims, as if something is listening.
Counterplay	Do what divers do: **hold your breath** and stay still while it passes, for example on the other side of a linked door.
Cost of failing	PROPOSED It reaches the linked thing nearest you. If you are touching it, the counting starts (7.3).

PROPOSED System notes: a breath meter with a heartbeat that rises as air runs out; holding too long makes Saskia gasp loudly (a noise spike). Sprinting and panic make breathing louder. The lamp's dimming is a readable gauge of how close the Thing is.

7.3 Behaviour 2: it counts to three CANON

Part	Detail
Trigger	The Thing touches something the player is touching.
The tell	In the dark, a little girl's voice counts: *"One..."* ... *"Two..."*. It is Saskia's own voice, from when she was six.
Counterplay	Let go, or tear or burn the tag, before it says **"three"**. This is Mum's rule 3.
Cost of failing	At "three", it is joined to you. PROPOSED Being joined drains your breath: the meter falls, vision greys, sound muffles. Burning the link frees you. If it takes enough, behaviour 4 happens.

7.4 Behaviour 3: the third breath CANON

Part	Detail
Trigger	Tess falls asleep. She now breathes through Saskia, and the Thing slips into the link.
The tell	Saskia's breathing gets heavy and her vision greys. In the quiet you hear **two breaths in time with yours, then a third**, right behind your ear.
Counterplay	Call Tess and wake her up. That pushes it out.

Cost of failing	PROPOSED The Thing takes breath from both sisters for as long as Tess sleeps. Too long, and behaviour 4 happens.

7.5 Behaviour 4: it walks you into the water CANON

- If it takes enough of your breath, it takes your body.
- The screen goes black. You wake up **standing waist-deep in the freezing floodwater** outside your house, with the front door wide open behind you.
- You cannot remember walking there. On the phone, still on the kitchen wall, Tess is screaming your name.
- It was walking you into the water, to drown you and keep the breath.

PROPOSED This is the game's main "failure" state instead of a death screen: the player must wade back to the door through the cold, which costs time and breath and may cost links. A second or third sleepwalk in a short time could be fatal (game over), or could happen only in the deep water.

7.6 What may be shown CANON

> **THE VISIBILITY RULE (REVISED BY THE CREATOR, 3 NOVEMBER 2026)**
>
> Until v2.0 the Thing was never seen. The creator has now given it a body and a name: **the Bound One** (7.8), and it is shown in the trailer. The old rule's spirit stays: it is **heard before it is seen** (breath, knocking pipes, a dimming lamp, the count), and when it is seen it is in the dark, lit only by the light the player carries or a failing lamp.

PROPOSED In the game, keep full sightings rare and earned: glimpses at the edge of the torch beam, a limb on a wall, the steam of its breath; a full reveal only at the big moments (the first time it comes for you, being walked into the water, the end). A pale, wet hand on glass (the trailer's first jump scare) is still the right way to show it from a distance.



Trailer v4, jump scare 1: the hand on the window. Mood reference.

7.7 The false Tess on the telephone PROPOSED

The Thing has their names, so it may be able to phone Saskia in Tess's voice. The only way to tell: **it has no breath, so false Tess never breathes between words**. Real Tess gasps and sighs; false Tess speaks smoothly and a little too slowly. The trailer's post-title stinger uses this (*"Saskia… open the front door."*). It came from an earlier draft that was replaced, so it needs the creator's OK before it is built (Q7).

7.8 The Bound One: the creature design CANON

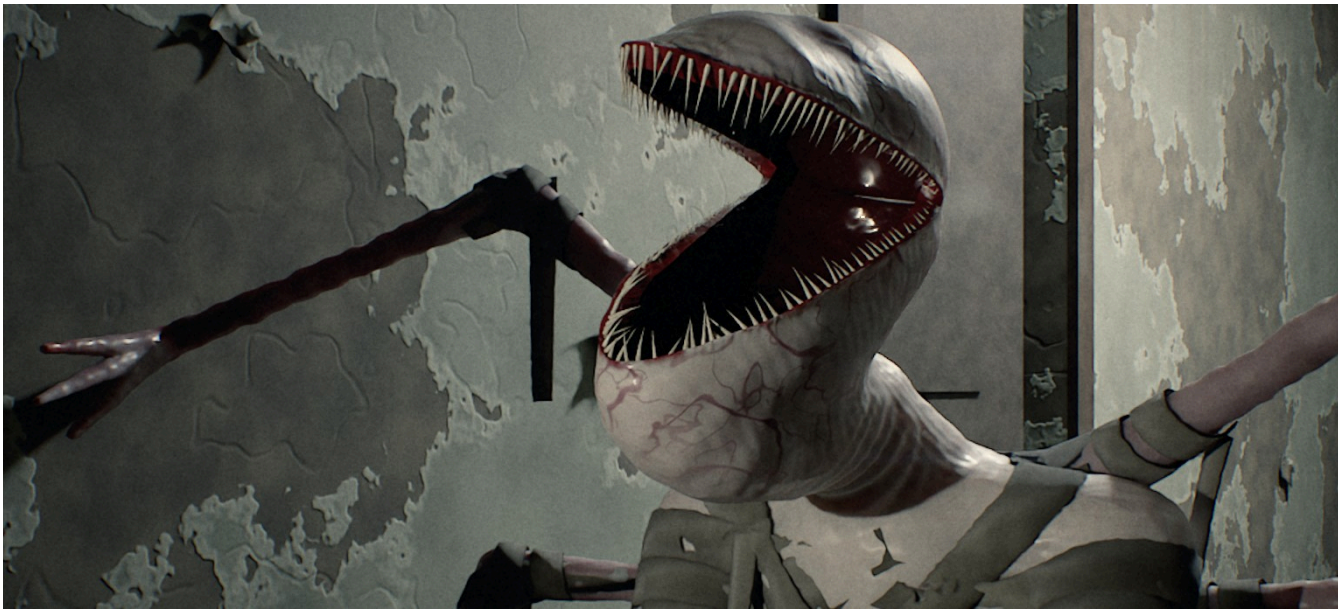
An eyeless, starved thing wound in grave linen, crawling on its hands with too many limbs, its whole head splitting open to breathe. CANON



The creator's concept art (3 November 2026): the design reference. The trailer's 3D model is built to match it.

Part	Design CANON (from the concept art)
Name	**The Bound One.** The family's word for it is still "the Thing"; "the Bound One" is the creator's name for the design.
Head	A tall, smooth, hairless egg of a skull, wider at the crown. **No eyes** (it is blind, as canon says: it hunts by breath). Pale skin with thin red-purple veins.
Mouth	A lipless slit from the front of the muzzle up both sides of the head almost to the crown. It opens like a lid: the whole upper head lifts away from the jaw, hinged at the back. Rows of long needle teeth on both edges, raw red gums, strings of spit.
Body	Human proportions, starved: ribs, spine and hip bones standing out, knobbed elbows and knees, long splayed fingers. Pale pink-white skin, translucent, red and raw at the joints and fingertips.
The extra limbs	Two more pairs of long, jointed limbs out of its upper back. The upper pair reach up and out to grip the walls; the middle pair reach down to the floor on long hooked claws. Darker, bloodied.
The bindings	Dirty linen bandages wound round its chest, arms and every extra limb, loose tails hanging; a torn linen shift from the waist, in rags to the floor. The look ties it to the game's central idea: *it is bound*, the way the sisters are bound.
Breath	Its breath is visible: it steams out of the open mouth even indoors.
Movement	It kneels and crawls on its hands, the extra limbs stepping along the walls and floor around it; the head low, swaying, cocked to listen (it is blind). When it has you, it rears up, the mouth splits open, and it lunges.

PROPOSED Readings to confirm with the creator (Q15): the steam is **stolen breath** (it has none of its own, so every breath you see is one it took); the bandages are what the fen buried it in; it is the size of a grown person, about 1.0 m high on its knees with the extra limbs spanning a corridor (about 1.6 m).



The 3D Bound One in the trailer's corridor (trailer v9, built in Blender from the concept art): it rears into the flashlight and the mouth splits open.



The crawl, through Saskia's eyes: head low, the extra limbs stepping along both walls, the robe dragging on the boards.

8 The story of the night

The **spine** below is canon. The **beats** under each act are a proposed breakdown for level design. Change them freely.

Act I: the game still works CANON spine

The flood. Tess trapped in the engine house. A lamp tag in Tess's handwriting: "So I know you're in." Saskia learns to link things to help her.

PROPOSED BEATS PROPOSED

1. **Arrival.** Saskia in the dark, wet cottage. Power is out, but one lamp is lit, with Tess's tag on it. The wall phone rings.
2. **The first call.** Tess is trapped as the water rises in the engine house. "Remember our game? Turn your lamp off." Her window goes dark across the water.
3. **Mum's wall.** The torch finds the four painted rules. Tess: "Mum hated that game."
4. **Room by room.** Tess describes what blocks her: a jammed door, a dark stair, a valve, a hatch. Saskia finds or makes the matching links in the cottage. Each puzzle is a small conversation.
5. **The first cost.** Helping Tess costs the cottage something: giving her light leaves Saskia in the dark; draining her room floods the kitchen.
6. **Act I ends** when a lamp dims on its own while Saskia is holding it, and the pipes knock.

Act II: something else knows the game CANON spine

Things start moving by themselves through the links. The Thing hunts by listening. The counting begins. Saskia finds Mum's notes and learns the truth about **SASKIA = TESS**. Tess sleeping becomes dangerous.

PROPOSED BEATS PROPOSED

1. **The first listening.** The hall lamp dims; the pipes knock closer. Saskia holds her breath. It passes.
2. **The first count.** "One…" "Two…" in a child's voice. The player learns to let go. Mum's rule 3 makes sense.
3. **Breaking to survive.** To shut a path the Thing is using, Saskia must burn a link that was helping Tess. Tess loses ground.
4. **Tess fades.** Exhausted, Tess starts drifting off on the line. The third breath. Saskia must wake her.
5. **Mum's tin and notes.** The reveal: **SASKIA = TESS**, the 1994 flood, the drowned tag.
6. **The sleepwalk.** Black. Saskia wakes waist-deep in the flood with the front door open behind her and Tess screaming on the phone. (This can happen earlier as a failure; here it is a scripted midpoint.)
7. **Act II ends** when Saskia understands the only way out: break the oldest link of all, and the tag is in the engine pit.

Act III: one breath CANON spine

To stop the Thing for ever, Saskia must break **SASKIA = TESS**. The original tag is at the bottom of the flooded engine pit, where the Thing is. She dives for it on one held breath. In the dark water a little voice starts counting, and she must break the tag before it says "three".

PROPOSED BEATS PROPOSED

1. **The crossing.** Saskia goes into the flood towards the engine house, guided by the beacon and Tess's voice.

2. **The engine house.** The sisters are in the same building for the first time tonight. Whether they meet before the dive is open (Q12).
3. **The dive.** One held breath into the engine pit, down past chains and the old pipework, torch in hand. The water is murky green; silt drifts in the beam.
4. **The count.** "One…" She finds the tag. "Two…"
5. **The choice** (section 9).

9 The endings

9.1 Break it: the good ending CANON

Saskia destroys **SASKIA = TESS**. Every link breaks. The Thing loses their names and sinks back into the water. Later, Tess falls asleep… and **breathes on her own**, for the first time in her life.

9.2 Keep it: the bad ending CANON

Saskia is too scared that Tess will die without the link, so she keeps it. They both live, but the Thing still has their names.

PROPOSED final image: (the earlier final shot, a tag written by the Thing, is retired.) Months later, Saskia in bed in a quiet room. We hear her breathing. Then, far away, Tess asleep. Then a third breath, close behind her ear. Black. A child's voice: "One…"

9.3 Breaking it underwater PROPOSED

The canon ending says she must "burn" the tag before the count reaches three, but paper cannot burn underwater. Recommended: **she tears it** (tearing also breaks links: canon rule 4) in the black water as the voice counts. Alternative: the top of the engine pit holds a pocket of trapped air under the floor; she surfaces into it and lights Mum's matches with shaking hands. (Open question Q3.)

> **THEME CHECK**
>
> The ending turns the game's core value into the final act: breaking a link is the good act. Saskia lets go of the bond that has secretly defined both sisters' lives, and trusts Tess to breathe for herself. Keeping it feels safe and loving, and it is the horror.

10 From story to game systems

This section is for Codex and other engineering work. It turns each story rule into a system. Everything here is PROPOSED engineering direction based on CANON rules. Keep systems in C++ and expose them to Blueprints; keep tunable numbers in data tables.

System	Story rule it serves	Suggested implementation
Link graph	Linking, sharing, "every link is a path"	A world subsystem that holds a graph: nodes are linkable objects, edges are tags. Each edge records its two nodes, its words, who made it and whether it is whole. State changes propagate along edges. The Thing travels along the same edges.
Linkable component	Things that can be joined	Added to any actor that can be linked. Declares its states (on/off, open/closed, wet/dry, sound) and how to apply a state change. Shows a tag mesh when tied.
Tag item and tag actions	Write, tie, touch both, count to three; tear or burn	Tags as inventory items with text. Actions: tie (attach to a linkable), touch-and-hold (a 3-count with an on-screen hand prompt), tear (instant), burn (needs matches; short animation). Names can never be written on a tag.
Breath system	Hold breath to hide; freediver; final dive	A breath meter and heart rate. Holding breath cuts the player's noise to zero but drains the meter; running out forces a loud gasp. Running and panic raise breathing noise. Shared with Tess while she sleeps.
Noise and hearing	It hunts by listening	Breathing, footsteps and actions emit noise events with loudness. The Thing "hears" noise near linked nodes.
The Thing (presence AI)	Never shown; moves through links	An invisible agent that moves node to node through the link graph, drawn by noise. It has no mesh. It drives the tells: lamp dimming on nodes it is near, pipe knocks, water sounds. It can only reach the player through linked things.
Counting event	"One… two…", let go before three	Starts when the Thing reaches a node the player is touching. Plays the child voice at fixed beats. Letting go, tearing or burning cancels it; reaching "three" joins the Thing to the player (breath drain).
Phone system	The sisters' only contact; keep Tess awake	A wall-mounted crank phone with branching voice lines. Tess has a wakefulness value that falls over time and rises when Saskia talks to her or rings her. Optional: false-Tess calls (Q7).
Tess sleep and the third breath	Rule 4; behaviour 3	When wakefulness reaches zero, Tess sleeps: Saskia's breath meter carries both, and the third-breath event begins. Ringing and talking wakes her.
Blackout and sleepwalk	Behaviour 4	When the breath taken passes a threshold: fade to black, teleport the player to the flood outside the open front door, then let them wade back. Doubles as the soft-fail state.
Swimming and diving	The crossing and the final dive	First-person wading, swimming and a diving mode that uses the breath meter. Underwater: murk, a torch beam, the count.
Story state and save	Acts, notes, endings	A simple story-flag system (act, discovered notes, links made and broken), a save at each phone call, and the ending choice.

Readability rules for systems PROPOSED

- Every threat has a **tell before it acts**: dimming lamp, pipe knocks, "One…". No unfair surprise deaths.
- Every rule is **shown once safely** before it can hurt the player.
- Linked objects always look linked (a tag hangs on them), so the player can always see the Thing's possible paths.

11 Tone, look and sound

11.1 Tone CANON

Realistic, scary, grounded. Psychological horror built on dread, silence and rules the player understands, with a few sharp scares that are earned. No gore. The emotional core is two sisters on a telephone in the dark.

11.2 Look CANON (from the creator's trailer feedback)

- Photoreal and physical. Water must move (flowing, rippling, rain hitting it); nothing should look frozen or like a still image.
- No 2D painted effects pretending to be physical: no fake ripple rings, fake drip sprites or cartoon rain streaks. Water, rain and wetness are rendered for real, or not at all.
- Night, practical light sources only: lamps, a torch, the beacon, lit windows. Darkness is a gameplay space.
- No monster, no gore, no logos. The Thing is never shown (section 7.6).

11.3 Sound CANON

- Real recorded sound for the world: rain, thunder, wind, water, drips, breathing, creaks, knocks, footsteps, the phone bell.
- Sound carries the horror: breathing (yours, Tess's, and a third), the counting voice, pipe knocks, silence before a scare.
- Tess on the phone is filtered like an old telephone line. The counting voice is a little girl, close and dry, as if right at your ear.

11.4 Horror grammar PROPOSED

- Long quiet stretches with real ambient sound; the player's own breathing is the loudest sound in the room.
- Scares come after true silence, are short, and are carried by sound.
- Repeat a pattern (the count) until the player trusts it, then use the pattern against them (for example a count that starts while the player is holding something they cannot let go of).

12 Voice and dialogue reference

12.1 Lines established by the v4 trailer CANON

Speaker	Line	Context
Tess	"Saskia? It's me. The water's in the engine house… I can't get out."	First phone call.
Tess	"Remember our game? Turn your lamp off."	Teaching the rule.
Tess	"See? It still works."	Her window goes dark.
Tess	"Mum hated that game."	Leads to Mum's wall.
Child's voice	"One…" "Two…" ("Three.")	The Thing counting, in Saskia's voice at six.
False Tess	"Saskia… open the front door."	Trailer stinger. Never breathes. PROPOSED for the game (Q7).
Tag (Tess's hand)	"So I know you're in."	Note on the kitchen lamp tag.

12.2 Trailer cards and title CANON for the trailer

- THE FENS · THE NIGHT OF THE FLOOD
- Link two things, and they share everything.
- At six, Saskia joined her breath to Tess's.
- Something in the water found their names.
- If it counts to three, it has you.
- Don't let her sleep.
- It wants their breath.
- One flood. · One breath. · Let go.
- THE BINDING · Every connection has a consequence.

12.3 Voice rules PROPOSED

- **Tess:** natural, breathy, interrupted; she gasps, sighs, laughs, swears softly. Her breathing is part of her voice: that is how the player trusts her.
- **False Tess:** the same voice with no breaths at all, perfectly smooth and slightly too slow. Never overused.
- **Saskia:** speaks little. Her breathing says more than her lines.
- **The child:** only ever counts. Never says anything else.
- Call her "Saskia" in full in key moments, so players learn the name that is on the tag.

13 Timeline and fact sheet

13.1 Timeline

When	What	Status
1988	Saskia is born (she is 38 in 2026).	CANON (derived)
1994	Tess is born (she is 32 in 2026). As a baby she keeps stopping breathing in her sleep.	CANON (derived)
1994	Saskia, six, writes **SASKIA = TESS** and joins their breath.	CANON
1994	The flood. The tag falls into the water. Something drowned finds it, and their names.	CANON
1994 onwards	Saskia breathes for Tess every night without knowing. Mum paints the rules on the kitchen wall.	CANON
Unknown	Saskia becomes a freediver; her career ends. She leaves home.	PROPOSED
Unknown	Mum dies.	CANON (date open)
The night (24 Oct 2026?)	The great flood. Tess trapped in the engine house; Saskia in the cottage. The game.	CANON (date proposed)

13.2 Fact sheet

Fact	Value
Player character	Saskia, 38, former freediver
Sister	Tess, 32; stops breathing when she sleeps
Mother	Dead; painted the four rules; kept the tin and notes
Antagonist	The Thing in the water; never shown; wants their breath
Contact between the sisters	Old crank wall telephone only
First link shown	**KITCHEN LAMP = ENGINE HOUSE LAMP**
The secret link	**SASKIA = TESS**, written by Saskia at six
Where the original tag is	The bottom of the flooded engine pit
How a link is made	Tag on both things, touch both, count to three
How a link is broken	Tear or burn the tag (always safe)
The Thing's four behaviours	Listens for breath · counts to three · the third breath · walks you into the water
Good ending	Break **SASKIA = TESS**: every link breaks; Tess breathes on her own
Bad ending	Keep it: both live; the Thing still has their names

14 Retired ideas: do not use

These came from earlier drafts. They were replaced or rejected by the creator. Older files may still contain them.

Retired idea	Why, and what replaced it
Dad drowned in 1994; the twist "DAD = HOME"; Dad is what comes through the links.	Replaced by the merged story: the Thing that found the sisters' names.
The Thing writes its own tags in wet handwriting ("BACK DOOR = SAS", "SAS = ME").	Creator: not scary enough. Replaced by the four hunting behaviours.
"It is always drowning": water dripping from light switches, rooms flooding with no water coming in, coughing up black water in a dry room, a drowned voice speaking through sleeping Tess.	Replaced by the four hunting behaviours (section 7). (The false-Tess phone voice survives only as a proposal: Q7.)
Short names on tags: "SAS = TESS".	Creator: use full names so the audience understands. Now **SASKIA = TESS**.
The trailer v3 rule: "touch the second thing within three seconds".	Creator: confusing. Replaced by: tie, touch both, count to three.
The v1.1 PDF story ("Held Breath"): Tess as the antagonist; her sleeping body reaching for breath; one match at a time; matching with a held breath and palms; lights that "breathe" and switching them off is the harm; the ventilator battery in 1994; decommissioning; Tess 37 hours awake.	The whole story was redesigned because the logic did not make sense. Only place names and craft notes may be reused (section 2.3).

15 Open questions for the creator

Each has a recommended answer that works as a default until you decide.

#	Question	Recommended answer
Q1	How can one tag join two things that are far apart?	Tags come in matching pairs, one on each thing; the link forms when both are touched as the count reaches three; destroying either tag breaks it (4.3).
Q2	What is the **SASKIA = TESS** tag in Mum's tin, if the original is in the pit?	Saskia's first attempt, never tied or touched. It has no power; Mum kept it as proof (6.3).
Q3	How is the tag "burned" at the bottom of a flooded pit?	She tears it underwater as the voice counts, or surfaces into an air pocket and burns it (9.3).
Q4	What is the final image of the bad ending?	The third breath in a quiet bedroom, then "One..." (9.2).
Q5	What does being joined to the Thing actually do?	It drains your breath until you break the link; enough drain causes the sleepwalk (7.3).
Q6	Why is Tess at the engine house tonight?	She stayed home and looks after the old pumping station.
Q7	Is the false Tess on the phone (never breathes) part of the game?	Yes, but rarely, and only after the player has learned to listen for breath (7.7).
Q8	Names: Moerland, Ruth, Coldmere Engine, 24 October 2026? Victorian steam engine house or 1928 diesel station?	Keep the names; use the Victorian engine house from the trailer.
Q9	How and when did Mum die?	A few years ago, of something ordinary. Her death left Saskia as the only one who could learn the truth.
Q10	Does Tess know about her condition?	She believes she grew out of it as a toddler; only Mum knew why she breathes at night.
Q11	Why did Saskia's diving career end?	Undecided. A quiet clue linked to breathing for two would fit.
Q12	Do the sisters meet in person before the end?	Yes, briefly, in the engine house before the dive. The only time they touch.
Q13	Game length and structure	About 4–6 hours in three acts; a 15-minute vertical slice first (cottage, first call, lamp link, first listening scare).
Q14	Is the title clear to use? Other works use "The Binding" (for example *The Binding of Isaac*).	Run a trademark search before any public release.
Q15	The Bound One: is its steaming breath the breath it has stolen? Are the bandages what the fen buried it in? How big is it?	Proposed in 7.8: yes; yes; a grown person's size, about 1.0 m high on its knees.

16 The v4 trailer, shot by shot

95 seconds, 24 frames per second, 2.39:1. It shows the canon story without giving away the ending. Use it as the reference for tone and for what the audience is told.

Time (s)	Picture	Sound
0–7	Black, then the fens at night. "THE FENS · THE NIGHT OF THE FLOOD".	Real rain and thunder; a phone ringing far away.
7–10	The old wall telephone rings; picked up.	Bell, pick-up, line hiss.
10–21	The engine house; the lamp tag; the switch; her window goes dark.	Tess: "Saskia? It's me...", "Remember our game? Turn your lamp off.", "See? It still works."
21–26	Card "Link two things, and they share everything."; the childhood drawing.	Tess: "Mum hated that game."
26–35	Mum's four rules, one by one, by torchlight.	Piano notes, string swell.
35–42.6	The **SASKIA = TESS** tag in Mum's tin; two cards.	Heartbeat; sub booms.
42.6–50	The hall lamp dims to nothing; black.	Breath held; pipe knocks getting closer; a child whispers "One..." "Two...".
50.0	**Jump scare 1**: a pale wet hand slams the window.	Sting.
51–58.6	Card "If it counts to three, it has you."; Tess asleep at her desk; card "Don't let her sleep."	Two breaths in sync, then a third.
58.6–65	Saskia waist-deep in the flood, front door open; card "It wants their breath."	A gasp, water, rain.
65–74	Montage: sluice, tag, Tess wakes, beacon, hall, underwater torch; "One flood." "One breath." "Let go."	Riser; whispers; cut to silence.
75–82	Title: THE BINDING · Every connection has a consequence.	Title hit.
82–88.8	The phone in the dark. "Tess": "Saskia... open the front door." (no breath). "Three." **Jump scare 2**: the hand again.	Silence, whisper, the loudest sting.
89.6–95	End card.	Drone fades out.

17 Change log

Version	Change
v1.1 (18 Oct 2026)	*Definitive Narrative Foundation*: the "Held Breath" story. Now superseded as story canon.
Redesign	The creator found the old game logic confusing and asked for a new story. Options were proposed; the creator chose to merge Option 1 (linking is the tool) with Option 3 (something found their names).
Horror pass 1	The Thing writing tags was rejected as not scary enough.
Horror pass 2	Approved: the Thing wants the sisters' breath; it listens for breath, counts to three, joins as a third breath, and walks you into the water.
Names	Full names on the tag (**SASKIA = TESS**) and in the voice lines, so audiences understand.
v2.0 (23 Oct 2026)	This Story Bible: canon collected, gaps proposed, retired ideas listed, open questions logged, systems mapped for Codex.
v2.1 (4 Nov 2026)	The creator gave the Thing a body and a name, **the Bound One** (concept art, 3 Nov). New section 7.8 (the design); 7.6 revised (it may now be shown, rarely and in the dark); the "never show the Thing" and "no monster design" rules in section 0 updated to match. The trailer (v9) ends with the 3D Bound One in the corridor.

To change canon: the creator decides; update this document; add a line to the change log; tell Codex and Claude to re-read it.